

Chapter - 5

SOCIAL AND RELIGIOUS REFORM MOVEMENTS



We learn the following in this chapter.

- *The establishment of the Brahmo Samaj and its reforms.*
- *Yuva Bengal Movement.*
- *The establishment of the Arya Samaj and its reforms.*
- *The reforms of the Prarthana Samaj.*
- *The teachings of the 'Satyashodhak Samaj'.*
- *Aligarh movement.*
- *The teachings of the Ramakrishna Mission.*
- *Theosophical Society.*
- *Narayana Guru : Dharma Paripalana Yogam.*
- *Periyar.*

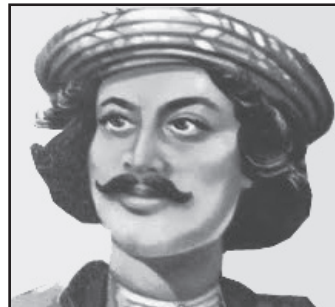
The 19th Century in Indian history is referred to as the period of 'Indian Renaissance'. Indians came into contact with Western civilization. As a result, they got the advantage of English education. Rationalism grew among Indians. It is a well-known fact that this rational attitude stimulated the Indians to question superstitions and the contradictions in their traditions, and also become aware of their own interests. In order to protect their political and economic interest, British administrators supported reforming movements. They tried to ban the evil practices which are harmful to society. Western thought introduced the ideas of democracy, freedom, equality and nationalism to Indians. Many who were enlightened by Western education, tried to bring in reforms. In this context, Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Dayanand Saraswati, Mahadev Govinda Ranade, Jyotiba Phule, Swami Vivekananda, Annie Besant, Syed Ahmed Khan, Narayana Guru, Periyar and others worked towards social reform.

Know this :

The British and Indian scholars who were influenced by the Western philosophers, called the 19th Century period 'a period of Renaissance'.

Brahmo Samaj

Ram Mohan Roy was one of the important person in establishment of Brahmo Samaj. He has been called 'The Father of Indian Renaissance'. He had received excellent education. He was well-versed in many languages like Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian, English, French, Greek, Latin and others. He had studied the culture and principles of religions like Hinduism, Islam, Sufi, Christianity and Buddhism. Raja Ram Mohan Roy studied the Upanishads and questioned the practice of idol-worship. He argued that modern science and English education were essential for an Indian revival. He opposed exploitation of women. He led an organized attack against the practice of sati and child marriage. Orthodox Hindus condemned him for such acts. Ram Mohan Roy supported the Prohibition of Sati Act which was introduced by Lord William Bentinck. He tried to develop rationalism among people through journalism. Towards that end, he started a newspaper in Bengali called 'Samvada Kaumudi'.



Ram Mohan Roy

Brahmo Samaj was in the forefront of the social and religious reformation in the 19th Century. It attempted to bring in reforms in the traditions and customs in Hindu religion. It opposed idol-worship and polytheism, and encouraged monotheism. It condemned performance of yagas and rituals. Since English education exposed Indians to Western political thought, it enabled the development of nationalism among Indians.

Activity: Make a list of the measures the government has taken to eradicate child marriage.

Young Bengal Movement

The wave of modernization started moving across North India during the nineteenth century. Calcutta was the Centre of this new thinking. New movements started arising during the C.E 1820s and 1830s. We have already learnt the contribution of Bramho Samaj. During this period, another movement called 'Young Bengal Movement' took birth. This movement was started by Henry Louis Vivian Derozio (1809-1831). His father was a Portuguese and his mother was an Indian. Hence, Derozio was called Anglo-Indian.

Derozio served as a professor at Hindu College in Calcutta. Many of his students who were attracted to his teaching became his committed followers. Derozio was influenced by the various movements of Europe

and tried to instil the same spirit of free enquiry in the minds of his students and colleagues. He also worked towards creating text books to inculcate new education system. This angered many traditionalists. He went ahead and started the 'Academic Association (1828), a free thinking debate association which created new thinking across Bengal.

The young Bengal movement held discussions and debates on issues like nature, humanism, God and other various topics. Derozio worked towards spreading the message that only rational thinking would liberate people from the clutches of superstitions and social discrimination. He was an advocate of Women Rights and opposed caste based discrimination. This grew into a new movement, but the influence of this movement was limited to Calcutta and a few areas of Bengal.

Arya Samaj

Arya Samaj was established by Dayananda Saraswati. He travelled throughout the country giving lectures and emphasized that the Vedas were the source of truth and knowledge. In this context, he advised people to 'Back to the Vedas'. He condemned idol worship and the caste system. He advocated that caste should be decided based on the ability and not on the birth of the person. He rejected the innumerable meaningless practices. He encouraged widow marriage. He urged people to use swadeshi goods. He propounded his teachings in a book called 'Satyarth Prakasha'. 'Purification Ritual' was the main activity of Arya Samaj. The Samaj established schools and colleges in many places. The principles of Swarajya and Swadharma advocated by Dayananda Saraswati inspired people to take part in the freedom movement. Dayananda Saraswati who was a great patriot, proclaimed that 'India should be for Indians'.



Dayananda Saraswati

Know this :

Purification Movement

The caste system and rigid beliefs of the Hindu religion had pushed people towards other religions. In this context, with an intention to integrate the Hindu society, Dayananda Saraswati reinterpreted the Vedas and advocated caste and gender equality. He began a Purification Ceremony to bring back to the Hindu religion all those who had got converted to other religions. Those who came back underwent the Purification ritual and were accepted by Hinduism. Thus he strengthened the Hindu religion.

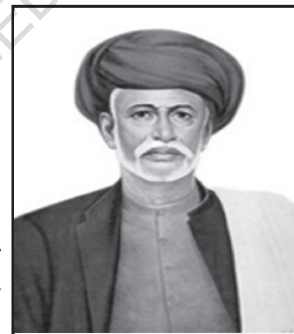
Prarthana Samaj

Prarthana Samaj was established by Atmaram Panduranga in Mumbai. It was founded on the principle that service to mankind is service to God. It gave priority to spread education. Through the Deccan Education Society, it aimed to develop the educational field. It encouraged widow marriage, female literacy, intercaste marriage, eating together by people of all castes, and opposed child marriage, caste system, idol worship and purdah system. It maintained that all religions were paths towards the truth and hence needed to be respected. During the Indian Renaissance, orphanages, national schools and shelter homes for women were established.

M.G.Ranade popularized Prarthana Samaj. He believed that progress in the political and economic fields was impossible without reform of the society. He propagated Hindu-Muslim unity. Ranade was active in the National Congress party. He started a high school for educating girls.

Satyashodak Samaj

Satyashodak Samaj was established by Jyotiba Phule. He believed that freedom was the basic necessity of every individual and that no individual could express his ideas if he did not have freedom. Satyashodak Samaj urged for prohibition of liquor. It vehemently opposed gender inequality, denial of human rights, exploitation of people and practice of untouchability. It started a movement for social justice. Jyotiba Phule established a primary school for girls. He condemned the slavery being forced on *shudras* and casteless classes including dalits, and denounced the people responsible for such slavery. He advocated free and compulsory education in order to bring about reform in the social system.



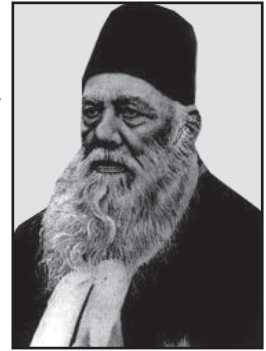
**Mahatma Jyotiba
Phule**

Activity: Learn from your teacher about the various schemes of the Karnataka Government that encourage women's education.

Shahu Maharaj who was deeply influenced by Satyashodhak Samaj, opened many branches of the Samaj and continued its activities. It began struggles on behalf of farmers. Phule wrote in detail about exploitation in his book 'Ghulamagiri' ('Slavery'). Phule's wife, Savitribai Phule too worked hard through the Satyashodhak Samaj, for women's education. Because of their effort a hostel for girls was started. The effort of Phule's family in establishing a new society on the base of the principles of equality was an important one. Later, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar was influenced by Phule's principles.

Aligarh Movement

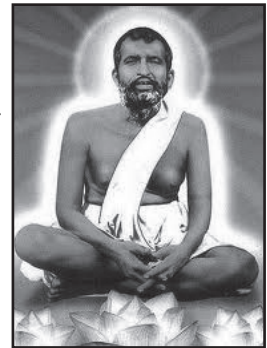
The Aligarh Movement aimed at promoting harmony of Eastern and Western ideas through transformation of the Muslims in their political, social, educational, religious and philosophical beliefs. The leadership of this movement was borne by Sir Syed Ahmed Khan. With an intention to provide modern education to the Muslim community, he started 'The Anglo-Oriental College'. Later on, this college was renamed as 'Aligarh Muslim University'. Its main objective was to provide religious education along with western education, and to create a modern society through western education. Sir Syed remained outside the National Congress and brought the Muslim community together. He supported female literacy and condemned polygamy and ideas against widow marriage.



Sir Syed Ahmed Khan

Ramakrishna Mission (1897)

Ramakrishna Paramahansa was a priest at the Dakshineswar Kali Temple. His thought was source of Indian culture. He considered all religions to be equal. He believed that spiritual realization was more important than any religion or God. He believed in idol-worship. He was a selfless devout person. Swami Vivekananda was his favorite disciple.



Ramakrishna Paramahansa

Swami Vivekananda established Ramakrishna Mission in order to propagate the ideals of his teacher, Ramakrishna Paramahansa. The main objective of this organization was to spread the message of equality of all religions and to put that into practice. Ramakrishna Ashram has many branches all over the world. The mingling of ancient, modern and western thinkers can be seen here.

Swami Vivekananda was a revolutionary monk who opened the eyes of Indians to the importance of loving life. He stressed the significance of the individual, his presence and ability. He maintained that apart from prayer and practice of yoga, social service was also necessary for achievement of salvation (moksha). Ramakrishna Mission is continuing to nurture culture through education and social service. Vivekananda emphasized that nation and religion were like the two faces of a coin. Many national leaders including Gandhiji were inspired by the philosophy



Swami Vivekananda

of Vivekananda. He tried his best in his lifetime to free India from casteism, poverty, illiteracy and unawareness. He believed that the desire of Vivekananda was to educate people. The educated people will bring reforms in the society. He wanted the formation of legislation and through legislation, social reforming rules must be implemented. He urged to stop the blind following of westerns.

In 1893, at the Chicago Conference of World Religions, Swami Vivekananda upheld the greatness of India by advocating tolerance of all religions, and maintaining that all religions were true. In this manner, he introduced Indian culture to the world. He was an inspiration to the youth.

Theosophical Society (Brahma Vidya Samaj)

The founders of Theosophical Society were Madam Blavatsky and Colonel H.S.Olcott. This society was founded on the principles of establishment of universal brotherhood, comparative study of ideology, and exploration of natural principles and the latent energy of the individual.



Annie Besant

Annie Besant, an Irish lady started the activities of Theosophical Society in India and gave it new vitality. She aroused pride in Indian culture through her lectures. She attempted to establish equality, universal brotherhood and harmony in society. Annie Besant gave her full support to the freedom struggle. She started a newspaper called 'New India'. In 1916 C.E, she started Home Rule movement. She was the President of the Congress Session in 1917. She contributed immensely to Indian philosophy and the Independence struggle.

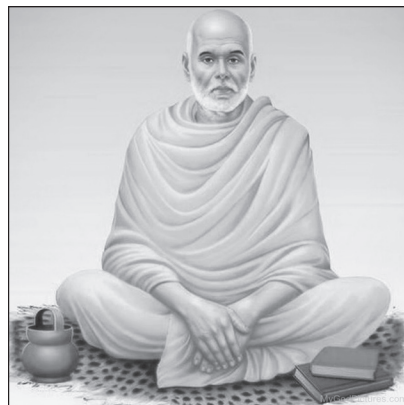
know this :

Home Rule

Ireland was under the control of Britain. The Irish people began the 'Home Rule Movement' in order to obtain the right to carry on the administration of their country themselves. Influenced by this, Annie Besant started the movement in India too. In 1916, two Home Rule Leagues came into existence. One began under the leadership of Tilak and had Pune as its centre. It had its branches in Maharashtra, North Karnataka, Central provinces and Berar areas. The second League began under the leadership of Annie Besant and had Madras as its centre. Tilak brought out the newspapers 'Maratha' and 'Kesari', while Annie Besant started 'New India' and 'Commonweal' propagated their ideas.

Sri Narayana Guru

Sri Narayana Guru started the Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana Yogam in 1903. He was born in Chembalanti / Chembalandi of Kerala. This movement aimed at strengthening the backward and exploited communities. Narayana Guru (1854-1928) and his companions Dr. Palpu and Kumaran Assan led the movement.



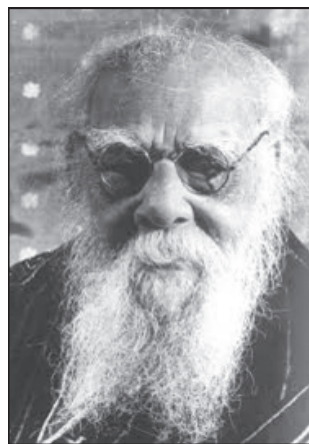
Sri Narayana Guru

The caste differences were too much in Kerala and there were many prohibitions in place. During that period, all were not allowed to use facilities like tanks and roads. They were barred from wearing footwear. Restrictions were there on women's dress also. They were not allowed to schools. These communities had to lead a suffocating life without basic human rights. In order to address this issue, Sri Narayana Guru started Dharma Paripalana Yogam movement. One Caste, One Religion and One God for human beings was the basic idea of Sri Narayana Guru. Education is the only path to achieve this he declared. He built alternate temples for the backward communities as they were denied entry into temples.

Narayana Guru and his companions started 'Vaikom Satyagraha Movement' in 1924, which demanded entry for lower caste people in the Shiva temple at Vaikom. Gandhiji and Periyar, the architects of self-respect movement participated in this. The Satyagraha for entry of untouchables into Guruvayoor temple was a major incident.

Periyar

By the beginning of twentieth century, a Non-Brahmin movement started in South India. Majority non-Brahmins launched agitations demanding representations in government sector as per their population. It became a major movement in Karnataka and many other states later. The non-Brahminical communities opposed restrictions against them. This was possible due to the English Education. The census reports published after 1870s, provided a picture of their population. The Justice Party started in 1916 continued the movement in Tamil Nadu.



Periyar

The non-Brahmin movement took a new shape under the Justice Party. This became more radical. 'Self-Respect Movement' led by E.V.Ramaswami Naicker became a new force. Ramaswamy who came out of Congress in 1925, started Self Respect League in 1926. He was called Periyar (Senior Person) out of love by people. Periyar was born in Erode in a rich family. He believed that Congress was in favour of Varna system and started a new movement based on Dravida Racial Identity. He said Tamil was the language of Dravidians. He championed equality and criticized caste and gender-based discrimination. He participated in the temple entry movement in 1924 held at Vaikom of Kerala. He became the president of the Justice Party in 1939. He started an association called 'Dravida Kazhagam'. He also started an English magazine under the title 'Revolt'.

Even today, Periyar remains as the ideological symbol in Tamil Nadu politics. This is more evident in all the political parties of Tamil Nadu retaining the word 'Dravida' with their names. The ideological non-Brahminical movement started by C.Ayothiadas pandit and T.M.Nayar was turned into a cultural movement by Periyar. His life goal was to establish religious harmony where there will be no inequality based on caste, religion and gender.

EXERCISES

I Fill in the blanks with suitable words:

1. The 19th Century is called the period of _____.
2. Raja Ram Mohan Roy started the newspaper _____.
3. The founder of Prarthana Samaj was _____.
4. Freedom was the basic necessity of every individual was believed by _____.
5. Swami Vivekananda's guru was _____.
6. Young Bengali movement was started by _____.

II Discuss the following in groups and write the answers:

7. What were the preachings of the Brahmo Samaj?
8. Analyse the call of Dayananda Saraswati to return to the Vedas.

9. Explain the reforms propagated by Satyashodhak Samaj.
10. Analyse the objectives of the Aligarh Movement.
11. Explain the vision of Ramakrishna Mission.
12. Which were the reforms brought about by Annie Besant?
13. Explain the contributions of Sri Narayana Guru Dharma Paripalana Yogam.
14. List out the highlights of Periyar movement.
15. Which were the principles advocated by Direjio?
16. What are the contributions of Swami Vivekananda to the Society?

III Activity:

1. Visit Ramakrishna Ashram and collect information about the views of Swami Vivekananda.

IV Projects:

1. Visit libraries and read books of social reforms. With the help of your teacher, collect information from the internet on the subject.
2. Learn from your teacher about the organizations working towards social reform.

